

RECIPE : *THE SEA THAT DREAMED*

Director: Roxanne Ducharme

Concept and intention

The film began from an emotional idea: a small underwater creature lost in a monochromatic sea who slowly finds hope through borrowed memories. I wanted to create a quiet, poetic story that could feel both fragile and otherworldly.

The visual world was built around three core elements:

- an empty, repetitive underwater landscape
- a strange but gentle axolotl-like creature
- a jar of eyes containing visions from above the water

These ideas shaped every creative and technical decision.

Writing and narration with ChatGPT

I began by describing the emotional tone and simple structure of the story to **ChatGPT**. Through a series of conversations, it helped me shape the narration in the style of a distant bedtime story, simple but not childish.

Key lines such as *"He had no memories, no sky, no shore"* and the closing *"When you carry dreams, you are never truly lost"* became emotional anchors. The final script blended AI-assisted phrasing with my own editing and rhythm, forming the backbone for pacing and timing.

Narration and music as structural guides

Before generating any images, I created the final narration with **ElevenLabs** and the music with **Suno**. These two elements established the emotional and rhythmic foundation of the film.

The narration determined the timing and duration of each shot, acting as the central rhythm of the edit, while the music, composed as a simple, melancholic cello-based piece, helped shape the emotional flow. Together, they became the scaffolding for the visuals and animation that followed.

Visual development with Midjourney and Runway References

I used **Midjourney** to generate all core visual material, including:

- the axolotl-inspired creature
- the empty, monochromatic underwater environments
- the jar of eyes
- the visions above the water
- and the post-transformation colorful images

I generated multiple versions for each element, selecting only those that captured the right tone.

I then uploaded the separate elements (creature, jar, and backgrounds) into **Runway References**. I used prompts to have the model create new images that combined all these elements into one coherent shot.

The selected images were then lightly retouched and color-balanced in **Photoshop** to ensure continuity across scenes.

Animation with Runway

I used **Runway Gen-4** to transform the **Midjourney** stills into animated shots. Each sequence was generated with carefully written text descriptions to create:

- the gentle drifting of the creature
- slow underwater movement

A few shots were created directly with text-to-video in **Runway**, without using **Midjourney** stills, such as:

- the tunnel sequence after the creature touches the jar
- the spreading of color during the transformation

I created many versions of each shot, refining until the animation felt organic and cinematic.

The goal was to give the sense of a camera moving through an underwater world, while keeping everything soft and fluid, as if time itself were drifting.

Editing and color arc

All animated clips were imported into **Adobe Premiere Pro**. The edit followed the narration, moving from a monochromatic sea to a vivid, colorful finale.

I adjusted the color grading, increasing saturation on the visions and post-transformation scenes so that the new colors would clearly stand out against the earlier monochromatic shots.

Music and sound

I designed a minimal underwater soundscape in **ElevenLabs** and **Epidemic Sound**, with low tones, soft bubbles, and distant rumbles so the world felt alive but quiet.

The music and effects were mixed to flow continuously behind the narration, acting like an emotional current rather than a separate element.

Final assembly

I balanced all elements into a cohesive whole: voice, music, sound, and AI-generated visuals.

Every layer was refined until the tools themselves disappeared and the focus remained on the story's emotional journey.

Finally, I upscaled the final version with **Topaz Video**.

Updated version (final festival submission)

Months after completing the original film, I created an updated version using the same structure, narration, and soundtrack, but with new imagery and animation using newer AI models.

I regenerated key visual images with **Gemini 2.5 Flash (Nano Banana)** to achieve a more cohesive and refined look for the environments and the creature. In parallel, I also redid much of the animation using more recent video generation models, such as **Kling 2.5** and **Veo 3**, in order to obtain smoother, more expressive motion and a stronger sense of depth and flow.

The update was not a new film, but a visual and motion upgrade built on the original edit. The emotional tone, pacing, and narrative arc remained the same. The final festival submission reflects this refined version, which builds on the earlier version as its foundation but is visually and dynamically more unified and polished.